The 6:15

MONDAY · OCTOBER 19, 2026 NO. 26

THE BOARD

CALENDAR · NEXT 10 DAYS

Tue 10/20	Knicks open 2026-27 title defense at MSG vs. Philadelphia, 7p ET (NBC) — LeBron James' debut as a Sixer, banner-raising for the 2025-26 championship (confirmed, multiple outlets). Netflix Q3 after close, consensus EPS ~$0.82-0.84 **(range, not a single wire figure)**. Coca-Cola Q3 pre-market, consensus EPS $0.87-0.90 across calendars **(not reconciled)**.
Wed-Fri 10/21-23	Tesla, IBM and other Q3 reports expected this window per data-provider calendars **(exact dates not verified this run)**.
Standing	FOMC Oct. 27-28 (cut odds still mid-teens-to-20s on Manifold, little changed; the Fed held 3.50%-3.75% at its June 17 meeting on a 9-3 vote, with all three dissenters wanting a hike, not a cut **(forecasting-site characterization, not a primary Fed source)**); OPEC+ next meets Nov. 1, having held output flat for a second straight month on Oct. 4 — the Dec. decision is now the live question; Nov. 3 midterms (Trump's self-imposed no-new-Iran-strikes deadline stands); no frontier-AI release, rocket launch or VC mega-round verified within the last 24-48h this run — sixth straight issue skipping this sub-bullet rather than padding it.

METRICS · ~6:10A ET; NO ICE/NYMEX SETTLE YET PRE-NY-OPEN

Oil / rates / dollar	Brent $108.60 (-1.15%, Yahoo BZ=F, 6:07a), up from $105-106 on 10/14 and further from $104.72 on 10/9. WTI (Dec. contract, rolled from Nov.) $98.35 (-0.68%, 6:07a) **(contract-month rollover, not directly comparable to issue No. 25's Nov. figure)**; spread ~$10.25. 2Y 4.74% / 10Y 5.09% / 30Y 5.43% (Treasury.gov daily yield curve, Fri. 10/16

	close — Monday's not yet posted); DXY 101.94 (+0.10%, 6:07a).
Equities / vol / gold / gas	S&P 500 futures 7,743.00 (+0.50%), Nasdaq 100 futures 29,724.00 (+1.13%), both 6:07a; VIX 18.59 (-7.01%, ~6:03a) **(single-sourced, large overnight move, not cross-verified)**; gold (Dec. future) $4,188.40 (+0.17%, 6:07a); AAA national retail gas $4.2953/gal today, down from $4.3333 on 10/14 despite the Brent rally.
Asia closes / Europe	Nikkei 225 64,916.70 (-0.62%, close); Hang Seng 24,186.83 (+0.52%) **(Yahoo dates this read Oct. 16 — stale by a trading day)**; Shanghai Composite 3,730.92 (+0.39%) **(page gives no date)**. Europe mid-session, not closed: FTSE 100 10,784.19 (-0.90%, 11:00a BST); DAX 25,338.61 (-1.11%, 12:01p CEST); CAC 40 7,844.02 (-1.42%, 12:01p CEST).

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Status	"Closed" to commercial shipping per straits.live's war-risk framing, Day 232 **(single-sourced framing)**.
Transits	2 vessels on Oct. 11 vs. 85/day pre-crisis baseline (IMF PortWatch via straits.live) **(8 days stale by the vendor's own admission)**; Iran says the strait remains closed, the US says vessels are still transiting, and straits.live says it can't yet adjudicate that dispute.
Strikes	straits.live's feed carries no 24h count or running total this morning. Reported overnight: Iran says two supertankers hit mines in Hormuz (Oct. 18) **(unverified, no major wire has independently confirmed)**; IRGC reports a tanker fire after a mine collision (Oct. 19 early a.m.); a separate tanker was hit off the Saudi Gulf coast, crew evacuated (Oct. 19 morning). UKMTO is reportedly struggling to track incidents because most targeted vessels no longer report in directly (Splash247).
Dark tankers / war-risk	172 of 264 screened tankers (65%) went AIS-dark in the last 24h vs. a 95.6 7-day baseline

	(straits.live itself says this is within ambient dropout noise, not a verified evasion count — a floor, not a count). War-risk ~$10.0M per VLCC transit, ~30x pre-crisis **(unchanged figure, 25 days stale)**. Crisis Pressure 87 (±7) "extreme," flat; Escalation Forecast 60 (±11) "high," down 1.

Methodology: transits (PortWatch, lagged by design), strikes (UKMTO/press aggregation, incomplete this morning), dark-hull counts and insurance premia (periodic, stale) measure different things over different periods; never averaged or differenced here. All straits.live figures single-sourced.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Season over — eliminated Oct. 7, swept by the Rays **(continuity)**.
Knicks	Opens 2026-27 regular season Tue. 10/20 vs. Philadelphia, raising the 2025-26 championship banner. Preseason finale vs. Toronto not verified this run; one thin, single-sourced report (Tixel) has Minnesota beating New York 122-104 on 10/12 **(unconfirmed elsewhere)**.
Northwestern	Beat Michigan State 24-21 on the road Oct. 17, now 5-1 overall, 2-1 Big Ten **(single-sourced via Wikipedia's season page)**. Hosts Rutgers Oct. 24.

LEAD

SAUDI ARABIA · INFLATION · THE FED

Riyadh's airport reopens after nine days — but the Houthi-driven oil spike is already sitting inside September's hot CPI and PPI prints

King Khalid International Airport reopened Saturday, Oct. 17, after being closed since the Oct. 10 missile barrage that killed at least 12 people and wounded roughly 300, per Saudi civil-aviation figures reported across multiple outlets. [fact] International capacity has not snapped back: Lufthansa, KLM, Air France and several Gulf and Asian carriers have extended cancellations past the reopening, and the broader air war has not stopped — Saudi authorities reported a

Houthi projectile hit a residential area of Najran on Sunday, Oct. 18, injuring six and damaging homes and vehicles, while the coalition said it intercepted two drones near Riyadh and the Eastern Province and a third, unattributed, drone near the capital that same morning. [NEW, fact] The Gulf Cooperation Council issued a formal statement Sunday condemning the Houthi campaign and framing an attack on any member state as an attack on all six, explicitly backing Saudi Arabia's right to respond; Egypt's national security council separately said it would support the kingdom, though Egypt's parliament postponed a vote on authorizing that support rather than taking it up Sunday as expected. [NEW, fact] None of this has produced the "firm" Saudi response promised after the Oct. 10 strike, and regional officials continue to describe Saudi interceptor stocks as strained from the sustained tempo of the barrages. [fact, continuity]

That's the security layer. The macro layer moved just as much, and in a way that ties directly back to it. September CPI, due as this brief went to press on Oct. 14 and unconfirmed in that issue, landed hot: headline inflation rose 0.6% on the month and 3.7% year-over-year, above the pre-release range of roughly 3.6%-3.7% cited last issue, with core CPI at 2.6% y/y, per the Bureau of Labor Statistics. [NEW, fact] The composition matters for this story specifically: energy CPI rose 5.2% on the month and 20.4% year-over-year, with gasoline up 9.1% m/m and 34.2% y/y — a direct line from the Hormuz-and-Houthi-driven crude rally (Brent has run from $104.72 on Oct. 9 to $108.60 this morning) into the headline number households and the Fed both watch. [fact] The next day's prints pushed the same direction harder: September PPI rose 1.3% m/m against a roughly 0.6% consensus, with core PPI up 0.7% against 0.3% expected and

the annual PPI rate at 6.3%; retail sales rose 0.8% m/m against a 0.3%-0.4% consensus, with gas-station receipts up 6.4% doing much of the work; initial jobless claims came in at 199,000, in line with expectations. [NEW, fact]

Read: two consecutive upside inflation surprises, both substantially energy-driven, land nine days before the Fed's Oct. 27-28 meeting and reinforce — rather than challenge — what prediction markets were already pricing: cut odds for that meeting sit in the mid-teens-to-20s on Manifold, little moved by the data, consistent with a Fed that held its target range at 3.50%-3.75% in June on a 9-3 vote where every dissent wanted a hike, not a cut. [read, flag: dissent characterization from a forecasting-site analysis, not a primary Fed transcript] This is the second-order consequence of the war worth tracking into next week's FOMC: a conflict that started as a shipping-and-insurance story in the Strait of Hormuz has become, via Saudi Arabia's refining and export capacity sitting adjacent to the front line, a direct input into the US inflation print — which narrows the Fed's room to respond to anything else that breaks between now and year-end. [read] Set against that: equity futures are constructive this morning (S&P +0.50%, Nasdaq +1.13%) and the VIX is down sharply overnight, even as Europe opens broadly lower (FTSE -0.90%, DAX -1.11%, CAC -1.42%) — a split tape that doesn't yet agree on how much the Gulf escalation matters to risk assets, separate from how much it matters to inflation. [read, flag: VIX move single-sourced, not cross-verified] Watch: whether the Houthis follow through on threats to widen targeting to Aramco's Dammam headquarters; whether Egypt's parliament actually authorizes support this week; and whether Tuesday's CPI-adjacent news cycle leaves any room for Netflix earnings or the Knicks' title-defense opener.

Worth flagging against the tape: issue No. 25 noted Trump's Oct. 6 prediction that consumer prices would "come tumbling down" as the Iran war ended; the actual September print moved the opposite direction, and the war itself has neither ended nor shown signs of doing so in the two weeks since. [fact/read]

ECONOMICS

Beyond the CPI/PPI pass-through covered in the Lead, the claims and consensus detail: initial jobless claims for the week ended Oct. 10 came in at 199,000 against a 199,000 consensus, with continuing claims around 1.71 million — no sign of labor-market stress to offset the inflation surprise. [NEW, fact] The prior week's claims figure was revised slightly higher, per the same release, though the exact revision wasn't independently re-verified this run. [flag] The June FOMC statement's 9-3 vote, with dissents reportedly favoring a hike rather than a cut, is being carried here for the first time as context for why cut-odds pricing barely moved on this week's hot prints **(single forecasting-site source, not confirmed against the Fed's own minutes)**. Pre-release CPI consensus ranges cited in issue No. 25 (3.6%-3.7% headline) bracketed the actual 3.7% print; the inconsistency flagged there has resolved into an actual, if unflattering, number. Taken together, a hot CPI, a hotter PPI, in-line claims and strong retail sales describe an economy still generating demand even as energy costs climb — the opposite of the stagflation-lite read some desks have floated, though this brief found no primary-source commentary from FOMC voters reacting to this specific data run. [flag, gap]

BUSINESS

Q3 bank earnings wrapped Wednesday-Thursday with results issue No. 25 could only preview. BlackRock's adjusted EPS came in at $15.93, up 38% y/y and above the roughly $14.13-$14.25 estimate range, with $205bn of net inflows lifting AUM to $15.49tn (+15% y/y) and revenue near $7.75bn. [NEW, fact] Morgan Stanley beat too: net revenue $20.3bn, net income $4.9bn, EPS $3.03, ROTCE 22.6% — roughly 4% above consensus on wealth-management strength. [NEW, fact] Bank of America missed: non-GAAP EPS $1.08, revenue $30.11bn (+3.1% y/y), after absorbing a $1.2bn regulatory fine from the US Treasury; sources disagree on net profit, citing figures from $6.5bn to $6.9bn, both down sharply from a year ago. [flag, not reconciled] Goldman Sachs' and Citigroup's actual Q3 prints were not verified this run — only pre-report estimates were located. [flag, continuity from issue No. 25] Taken as a set, the bank quarter reads as a wealth-and-markets story (BlackRock, Morgan Stanley) outrunning a consumer-and-regulatory one (Bank of America's fine), with Goldman and Citi's actual results still the open question heading into next quarter's comparisons.

TECHNOLOGY

Rocket Lab said Oct. 14 that Neutron's inaugural launch has slipped into 2027, moving the rocket out of this year's launch window entirely — the most concrete update located this run on the frontier-launch calendar the Board tracks. [NEW, fact] No Starship or New Glenn update was located; Blue Origin's New Glenn return-to-flight timeline, following the August engine-failure finding, remains unconfirmed this run. [flag, continuity] Separately, a venture-funding tracker's weekly roundup (covering Oct. 7-14, since lapsed into last week) recorded roughly $5.6bn across 64 US rounds, led by TypeSafe AI's $870m Series A (a16z) and Manus's $500m-plus

round (IDG Capital). [flag, single-tracker source, window already a week old] No frontier AI model release was confirmed this run; the speculative Gemini/Fable/GPT release-week chatter flagged in weeks past still has no confirmed drop. The pattern across both items is the same one this brief has carried for six straight issues: capital and hardware announcements keep arriving on a steady cadence, while the headline-grabbing launches — a new flagship model, a maiden orbital flight — keep slipping right.

GEOPOLITICS

The Saudi-Houthi air war sits inside a wider regional alignment shift this week. Beyond the GCC's collective-defense statement covered in the Lead, Houthi media claimed a Saudi airstrike on a home in Saada killed nine people and wounded 16 on Sunday — a Houthi-sourced claim with no independent confirmation located this run. [NEW, flag] Egypt's parliament postponing its authorization vote, rather than passing or rejecting it, leaves open how far the kingdom's regional backers are willing to go beyond statements. [fact] OPEC+'s Nov. 1 meeting now carries more weight than the group's own Oct. 4 "hold" framing suggested: having kept output flat for a second straight month, the Dec. production level is the live decision, against a backdrop of Brent near $109 that gives the group less incentive to add barrels than it had in the spring. [read] Saudi Arabia's own position is awkward here — the kingdom both chairs the group managing supply and sits at the center of the attacks pushing price upward, a tension this brief has not seen addressed on the record by any OPEC+ official this run. [flag, gap]

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the Board's counters, this morning's Hormuz incidents carry a specific wrinkle: Iran's claim that two supertankers struck mines on Oct. 18, followed by an IRGC report of a tanker fire from a separate mine collision early Oct. 19, continues the mine-versus-projectile ambiguity flagged in issue No. 25 — no major wire has independently corroborated either mine claim, and straits.live's own feed says as much. [NEW, flag] UKMTO's reported difficulty tracking incidents, because targeted vessels increasingly don't report

in directly, is itself a new data-quality problem for every count on the Board this issue, not just an incident footnote. [NEW, flag] On diplomacy: Trump said over the weekend a decision on Iran is coming "very soon" without specifying its direction, while again ruling out nuclear weapons or ground troops against Iran. [fact] Iran's foreign ministry rejected any claim that Tehran directs Houthi operations and repeated an offer to mediate between the Houthis and Riyadh; separately, Iran is reported to be still reviewing a US seven-day-ceasefire proposal through indirect talks, even as Trump has publicly rejected an earlier Iranian offer — a sequence this brief cannot fully reconcile from a single wire account and is carrying with that caveat attached. [NEW, flag, single-sourced via Iran International] None of this disturbs the Oct. 8 pledge to hold off new US strikes until after the Nov. 3 midterms. On the insurance side, no fresh underwriter indications were located this run; Breakwave's Sept. 8 read (7.5%-12.5% of hull value per transit) and Signal Ocean's July 15 tanker-positioning snapshot both carry forward unchanged and are now five-plus weeks stale, a gap this brief can't close without a primary update from either vendor. [flag, continuity]

SPORTS

Yankees	Season over; eliminated Oct. 7, swept by Tampa Bay in the ALDS.
Knicks	Defending NBA champions open the 2026-27 season Tue. 10/20 at home vs. Philadelphia, banner night. Preseason finale vs. Toronto not verified this run; a single thin report has a 122-104 preseason loss to Minnesota on 10/12 (unconfirmed elsewhere).
Northwestern	Won 24-21 at Michigan State Oct. 17; now 5-1 overall, 2-1 Big Ten (single-sourced); hosts Rutgers Oct. 24.

Continuity. Politics is cut entirely this issue — no fresh, independently verified domestic political item was located beyond the standing Nov. 3 midterm marker already carried on the Board. The Dec. 11 FY2027 funding thread remains retired per issue No. 25. The CPI pre-release range flagged as unreconciled in issue No. 25 is resolved: the actual print (3.7% headline, 2.6% core) is now on record. Watch for next issue: Saudi Arabia's still-unfulfilled "firm" response and whether Aramco's Dammam HQ is actually targeted; Egypt's delayed parliamentary vote; Tuesday's Netflix/Coca-Cola prints and the Knicks' opener; Tesla/IBM earnings-date confirmation; any resolution of the Oct. 18-19 Hormuz mine claims.

Unverified figures are marked in red above. Single- or state-sourced this issue: both Iranian/IRGC mine claims on Oct. 18-19 Hormuz incidents; the Houthi claim of a Saudi strike killing nine in Saada; all straits.live Hormuz figures (status framing, transit lag, dark-tanker floor, war-risk premium, Crisis Pressure/Escalation Forecast scores); the June FOMC 9-3 dissent characterization; Fed-cut-odds prediction-market readings; the Knicks' Minnesota preseason score and all unconfirmed preseason results; Northwestern's score and record (single Wikipedia source); Bank of America's net-profit figure ($6.5bn-$6.9bn, not reconciled); Goldman Sachs' and Citigroup's actual Q3 prints (still only estimates found); Tesla/IBM earnings dates; Hang Seng's and Shanghai's exact as-of dates on today's quotes; the Iran-ceasefire-review/talks sequence (single wire source). Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.